AI MOVIE LAB | FLAGSHIP CASE STUDY | V1.4 TECHNICAL EDITION

CONCEPT > STORYBOARD > MOTION > FINAL CUT

Sui Dhaaga:

The Road Trip Tailors

सुई धागे से देश तक | *Sui Dhaaga Se Desh Tak*

A flagship, end-to-end case study in creating an AI short film - from conversation to final cut

25-second short film | Claude Cowork + ChatGPT Codex + Google Gemini + Pika + Microsoft Clipchamp

Designed as a replicable studio exercise for beginning AI filmmakers.

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How to use this guide

This is a teaching reconstruction of the completed project. It records the working decisions, production prompts, and practical corrections that turn a promising AI image sequence into a short film with emotional continuity.

LEARNING OUTCOME By the end, a new student should be able to take a theme, turn it into audience-tested story options, lock a five-shot visual plan, animate stills responsibly, and assemble a finished 16:9 film with sound and an end title.

Course map

01 Start with an idea conversation

02 Ask an audience to choose the premise

03 Build a five-scene visual storyboard

04 Generate locked still images in Google Gemini

05 Animate five-second clips in Pika

06 Edit, score, title, and export in Microsoft Clipchamp

07 Use the replication checklist and flow diagram

08 Publish the film and archive the project publicly

Project at a glance

Final runtime	25 seconds
Structure	Five scenes x approximately 5 seconds
Core tools	Claude Chat / Cowork with Fable 5; ChatGPT Codex with 5.6 Terra; Google Gemini (still images); Pika (image-to-video); Microsoft Clipchamp (edit and score)
Creative rule	One recurring van, two recurring characters, and a single emotional through-line

1. Ideation: begin with a human engine

The strongest AI-film prompts do not begin with a camera instruction. They begin with a pressure point: someone wants something, something is at risk, and the story can be expressed visually. Here the emotional engine was continuity between an elderly tailor and his son.

The Claude conversation

The ideation phase began in the chat experience of Claude using the Fable 5 model. Use the model as a development partner, not as a script vending machine: ask for a small slate of premises that can be told in five images and that share recurring characters, costume, prop, and a clear ending.

REUSABLE CLAUDE PROMPT I want a 25-second, dialogue-free Indian short film that can be made from five AI-generated images. Give me four emotionally distinct concepts. Each must have a strong visual hook, one recurring prop, two recurring characters, and an ending that can be understood without spoken exposition.

Model hand-off: Claude to Codex

After the initial ideation, the project moved into Claude Cowork using the same Fable 5 model. At the time of this project, access to that model was free until 19 July. The work paused after the daily limit was reached. The remaining production was then transferred to ChatGPT Codex using the 5.6 Terra model.

WHAT MADE THE TRANSFER WORK Project briefs were created and stored at each major stage. Those briefs carried the selected concept, visual anchors, approved images, prompts, scene order, and edit decisions. This made it possible to toggle between two flagship AI models without restarting the creative work.

What belongs in every hand-off brief

- The latest one-sentence story premise and the selected audience choice.
- Character, vehicle, costume, and palette continuity anchors.
- Approved still images, file names, scene numbers, and the reason each image was selected.
- Exact prompts already used, plus notes on what worked and what must not change.
- Current task, next action, known limitations, and the desired final runtime.

Four audience-facing concept options

#	Option	Why it could work
1	**The Last Projectionist**	A fading cinema becomes a place where a parent and child preserve shared memory.

2	**The River Letter**	A letter travels through changing landscapes and reconnects a family.
3	**The Road Trip Tailors**	A father-son mobile tailoring studio carries craft, service, and family identity across India.
4	**The Monsoon Postcard**	A young artist sends a visual message home through rain-soaked streets.

AUDIENCE CHOICE Present the four options in one slide or chat poll. Ask voters to choose the premise they would most want to see as a five-shot film and explain why. In this project, the selected concept was The Road Trip Tailors.

Why the chosen idea won

- The teal van is a memorable recurring production-design anchor.
- Tailoring supplies tactile action for image-to-video motion.
- A father and son give the film a readable emotional arc without dialogue.
- India-wide locations create variety while the van preserves continuity.

Lock a master reference image: the poster

Before any scene still existed, the project locked a 2:3 photorealistic poster in Google Gemini through three STRICT IMAGE EDIT refinement rounds. The poster is the single source of truth for the father, the son, the van, the four-craft garment, and the bilingual title identity (सुई धागे से देश तक / Sui Dhaaga Se Desh Tak). Every later still was generated with the poster attached as reference and the instruction that characters and vehicle must appear identical. Scene prompts describe the situation; the poster carries the people.

The locked master poster: both characters, the van with the DL 04 1974 plate, the four-craft garment, and the title in Devanagari and English.

MASTER REFERENCE RULE Poster edits used the pattern "STRICT IMAGE EDIT - NOT A NEW GENERATION" with an explicit preserve-list, numbered edits only, and a built-in fallback ("if it cannot be done cleanly, leave unchanged"). This is the highest-leverage continuity technique in the whole project.

2. Pre-production: lock the visual bible

Before generating any image, write a continuity bible. This prevents the classic AI-film problem: every scene is individually attractive but the film does not feel like one world.

Non-negotiable continuity anchors

- Vehicle: weathered teal-green 1970s van; folk-painted; mobile tailoring studio; rear doors/hatch visible when useful.
- Father: elderly tailor, white kurta, yellow measuring tape, calm and observant.
- Son: young adult, indigo/blue waistcoat or jacket, practical and warm.
- Texture: fabric, thread, zari, rain sheen, dust, fireflies; each scene must have a physical detail to animate.
- Tone: gentle, cinematic, emotionally restrained; no dialogue and no overt advertising.
- Backstory in design: the shop signboard "दर्ज़ी - Since 1974" and the van plate DL 04 1974 encode the year the father began tailoring - silent exposition that rewards attentive viewers.

INSTRUCTOR NOTE Do not ask a generator to “make it consistent.” Re-state the anchors in every prompt. Consistency is the result of repetition, selection, and correction.

Storyboard at a glance

Time	Beat	Visual intention
0:00-0:05	**Departure**	A father watches his son load handpicked cloth into a teal mobile tailor van. The emotional question: can a family craft move forward without losing its roots?
0:05-0:10	**Threads of Kutch**	In the salt desert, embroidery becomes a living exchange between maker, cloth, and community. The scene widens the world while keeping the van and characters recognizable.
0:10-0:15	**Temple Thread**	A temple street brings zari, rain sheen, and lantern warmth into the story. Detail work provides the film's tactile centre.
0:15-0:20	**Bengal Finale**	The completed garment is held in front of the warmly lit van among paddy fields and fireflies. It resolves the collaboration in a human, not commercial,

		register.
0:20-0:25	**The Road Continues**	At blue hour, the teal van drives away down a Bengal village road. Tail-lights recede; the final words, 'the journey continues..', arrive only in the final two seconds.

3. The five-scene visual storyboard

Each scene below pairs a visual purpose with a still-image prompt, animation plan, and continuity check. Use it as the student’s shot list.

SCOPE DECISION The original concept was a one-minute, eight-scene film touching all four corners of India, including a Kashmir sozni stop and a map scene. It was deliberately descoped to five scenes / 25 seconds to fit free-tier limits. The North stop was cut because it added a location without advancing the father-son arc. Descoping is a production skill: cut locations, never continuity.

01. Departure | 0:00-0:05

Story function

A father watches his son load handpicked cloth into a teal mobile tailor van. The emotional question: can a family craft move forward without losing its roots?

Movement cue

Son loads cloth; father turns gently; dust moves.

STILL-IMAGE PROMPT

Cinematic dawn in a narrow Indian bazaar. An elderly tailor in a white kurta with a yellow measuring tape stands in his doorway while his son in a blue waistcoat loads folded colourful fabrics into a weathered teal-green 1970s folk-painted van marked TAILORS ON WHEELS. Warm dust, realistic skin, 16:9, no watermark.

CONTINUITY CHECK Same van paint and weathering; same two characters; golden dawn palette.

02. Threads of Kutch | 0:05-0:10

Story function

In the salt desert, embroidery becomes a living exchange between maker, cloth, and community. The scene widens the world while keeping the van and characters recognizable.

Movement cue

Needle, garment edge, and salt dust move; slow arc.

STILL-IMAGE PROMPT

Cinematic late afternoon on the Kutch salt desert. The same teal-green tailoring van, the elderly tailor hand-stitching a red-and-indigo mirror-work garment, and the same son steadying the cloth. Distant women in traditional Kutch dress, warm wind, realistic Indian craft detail, 16:9, no watermark.

CONTINUITY CHECK Keep the van, father, son, and garment colours recognisable.

03. Temple Thread | 0:10-0:15

Story function

A temple street brings zari, rain sheen, and lantern warmth into the story. Detail work provides the film's tactile centre.

Movement cue

Hand smooths zari; fabric breathes; rack focus.

STILL-IMAGE PROMPT

Cinematic early evening outside a South Indian temple after rain. The same teal-green tailoring van; the elderly tailor smooths a gold zari border while the son holds a Kanjeevaram saree. Lanterns, wet stone reflections, temple gopuram, restrained wedding guests, 16:9, no watermark.

CONTINUITY CHECK Keep the van and blue waistcoat; avoid swapping the father’s costume.

04. Bengal Finale | 0:15-0:20

Story function

The completed garment is held in front of the warmly lit van among paddy fields and fireflies. It resolves the collaboration in a human, not commercial, register.

Movement cue

Garment lifts slightly; fireflies drift; gentle pull-back.

STILL-IMAGE PROMPT

Cinematic blue-hour Bengal paddy fields after rain. The same father and son proudly hold a completed patchwork garment in front of their open, warmly lit teal-green tailoring van. Banyan tree, fireflies, wet path, 16:9, no watermark.

CONTINUITY CHECK The van interior light should motivate the warm/cool contrast.

05. The Road Continues | 0:20-0:25

Story function

At blue hour, the teal van drives away down a Bengal village road. Tail-lights recede; the final words, 'the journey continues..', arrive only in the final two seconds.

Movement cue

Van moves away; tail-lights shrink; paddy shifts in breeze.

STILL-IMAGE PROMPT

Cinematic blue-hour Bengal village road after rain. The same weathered teal-green 1970s tailoring van drives away from camera between paddy fields; warm tail-lights recede into mist. Distant banyan silhouette, fireflies, locked-off wide 16:9 frame. No readable text, no logo, no extra vehicles.

CONTINUITY CHECK No AI text on the van; add end title later in the editor.

4. Still-image generation in Google Gemini

Google Gemini was used to turn the storyboard into image references. The goal was not to generate “the final film frame” in a single attempt. The goal was to create a locked reference for each shot that could survive animation.

Google Gemini workflow

1. Open a fresh image-generation conversation and set the aspect ratio to 16:9.
2. Generate one scene at a time; do not generate all five as a batch.
3. Evaluate for character continuity, van identity, readable action, and clean composition.
4. Rename/download the approved still immediately with a scene number.
5. If an image drifts, revise only the weak variable: location, garment, age, or camera distance. Do not rewrite the entire story every time.

SELECTION RULE Choose the image that gives the video model room to move. A clear hand action, breathing space around subjects, and a stable camera perspective are more useful than the prettiest still.

Common Google Gemini corrections

Problem	Correction
Characters drift	Repeat age, clothing, relationship, and the yellow tape / blue waistcoat anchor.
Van changes shape	Describe its era, colour, paint, weathering, and use the previous approved frame as reference when possible.
Text is gibberish	Treat AI text as unreliable. Keep vehicle lettering non-essential; build the real end title in Microsoft Clipchamp.
Scene feels static	Add an object that can move: cloth, thread, rain, fireflies, dust, or a driving van.

Worked example from the final film: in Scene 5 the van's rear lettering drifted into garbled "TAILORS OH WHELL..." forms. The correction table above exists because of shots like this - keep essential text out of generated frames and treat vehicle lettering as decorative texture, not information.

5. Image-to-video in Pika

Pika converts one approved still into a five-second shot. The prompt should not re-describe every pixel; it should tell the model what changes over time, how the camera behaves, and what must remain fixed.

PIKA SETUP Upload one approved image at a time. Choose a five-second generation, keep the image as the primary visual reference, and generate a single scene before moving to the next. This makes troubleshooting and credit use manageable.

WATERMARK REALITY The still-image prompts say "no watermark", but a prompt cannot remove a platform watermark: Pika's free plan brands every exported frame, and that brand is visible throughout the finished film. Plan for it - accept it in a student exercise, upgrade the plan, or switch engines for a clean deliverable. Do not edit a watermark out in post; removing it breaches platform terms.

Pika prompt - Scene 1: Departure

A gentle cinematic dawn departure. The elderly tailor pauses at the shop doorway, softly turning his head toward his son with a warm, proud expression; the yellow measuring tape moves subtly in the breeze. The son slowly lifts and settles the colourful fabric bolts into the open teal-green van. Fine dust motes drift through golden morning light; faint breeze moves fabric and clothing. Slow, subtle camera push-in with natural human motion. Preserve faces, wardrobe, shop, van, and framing. No text, warping, or extra people.

WHY THIS PROMPT WORKS It limits motion to a few believable actions and protects faces.

Pika prompt - Scene 2: Threads of Kutch

Cinematic late-afternoon Kutch salt desert. The elderly tailor's hands guide the needle through the red-and-indigo mirror-work garment while his son gently steadies the fabric. A warm desert breeze lifts the garment's edge; fine salt dust drifts across the ground. The distant women remain respectfully soft and still. Slow, graceful camera arc and subtle push-in, natural human movement. Preserve faces, wardrobe, van, garment, and framing. No text, warping, or extra people.

WHY THIS PROMPT WORKS It gives the needle, cloth, dust, and camera one job each.

Pika prompt - Scene 3: Temple Thread

Cinematic early evening temple street after rain. The elderly tailor delicately smooths the golden Kanjeevaram zari border while his son keeps the saree gently lifted so it catches the warm lantern light. A light breeze stirs the fabric; rain-slick stone reflects the temple lamps. The softly blurred wedding guests stay calm in the background. Slow rack focus from the shimmering gold border to the father's focused face, then a subtle push-in. Preserve faces, wardrobe, van, saree, temple, and framing. No text, warping, or extra people.

WHY THIS PROMPT WORKS It makes the visual focus move from textile detail to the maker.

Pika prompt - Scene 4: Bengal Finale

Cinematic blue-hour Bengal paddy fields after rain. The elderly tailor and his son share a quiet proud smile as they slowly raise and hold the completed patchwork garment before the open, warmly lit teal-green van. Fireflies drift through the cool evening air; paddy leaves and the garment move gently in the breeze. Slow, wide tracking pull-back revealing the banyan tree and glowing mobile studio. Preserve faces, wardrobe, van, garment, field, and framing. No text, warping, or extra people.

WHY THIS PROMPT WORKS It resolves the arc with a subtle performance, not an exaggerated gesture.

Pika prompt - Scene 5: The Road Continues

Cinematic 16:9 blue-hour Bengal village road after rain. The same weathered teal-green 1970s tailoring van, with its warm interior light glowing, slowly drives away from camera along a narrow road between lush paddy fields beneath a distant banyan silhouette. Its warm red tail-lights recede gently into the misty blue evening. A few fireflies drift over the roadside; soft monsoon haze and a calm breeze move the paddy leaves. Slow locked-off wide shot, emotional and understated. Preserve the van's folk-painted character and authentic cinematic realism. No readable text, no logos, no watermark, no extra vehicles.

WHY THIS PROMPT WORKS It asks for vehicle movement, atmosphere, and a locked camera, while banning generated typography.

6. Edit and finish in Microsoft Clipchamp

The edit stage is where separate AI outputs become a film. The discipline is restraint: let each five-second moment play, keep the cut structure simple, and reserve the only text for the ending.

Timeline blueprint

Time	Clip	Edit instruction
0:00-0:05	**Departure**	Hard cut in; let the dawn mood establish.
0:05-0:10	**Kutch**	Hard cut; new geography, same van and characters.
0:10-0:15	**Temple**	Hard cut; shift attention to handwork.
0:15-0:20	**Bengal finale**	Hard cut for an exact 25-second structure.
0:20-0:25	**The Road Continues**	Apply about 0.8-1.0 second fade-out at the end only.

IMPORTANT EDIT LESSON A Microsoft Clipchamp Cross fade overlaps clips, so the total runtime becomes shorter by the transition duration. For a precise 25-second assignment, use hard cuts between the five clips and fade only the final scene within its own clip.

End-title treatment

- Text: the journey continues..
- Placement: lower-centre over Scene 5.
- Timing: 0:23-0:25.
- Colour: warm white / soft ivory; small scale.
- Motion: about 1 second Fade in on the text layer; no generated typography inside Pika.

SPEC VS EXECUTION The exported film's title actually rendered as large green handwritten-style text centred mid-frame - not the small warm-ivory lower-centre treatment specified above. The spec exists because novelty typography competes with the image at the exact moment the film should feel quiet. For a polished cut, re-export with the documented treatment.

The end title as exported: bright green casual lettering, mid-frame. Compare with the specification above.

Background score workflow

- Open Content library, select Music rather than Sound effects, and choose a free non-premium instrumental.
- Search cinematic ambient, acoustic, or emotional; preview before adding.
- Drag the music to the audio lane at 0:00, split at the end of the video, and delete the excess.
- Set volume around 15-20%; use a 1-second fade-out at the end.
- Export 1080p once picture, title, and music have been checked full-screen.

7. Technical decision log: choosing tools, not just using tools

This project was not a single-tool workflow. Each platform was selected against an immediate production constraint: ideation depth, session availability, reference-based image generation, economical image-to-video, browser-editing access, or a clean export path. The governing principle was to preserve the creative brief while allowing the tool to change.

Selection matrix from the actual project

Stage	Candidates explored	Final choice + configuration	Why the decision held
Ideation	Claude Chat; Claude Cowork; ChatGPT Codex	Claude Chat, Fable 5; then Cowork	Best early-stage dialogue and option generation; Cowork continued the project context.
Limit fallback	Claude Cowork daily limit; ChatGPT Codex	Codex, 5.6 Terra	The saved hand-off brief allowed the remaining work to continue without rewriting the project from zero.
Still images	Multiple prompt iterations in Google Gemini	Google Gemini, 16:9 stills	Fast scene-by-scene visual locking; each approved still became the motion source.
Video generation	Kling considered; Pika tested	Pika image-to-video, 5 sec per scene	Pika was selected as the usable free path and made the 5 x 5-second structure manageable.
Assembly	Transition-heavy edit vs exact-duration edit	Microsoft Clipchamp, 16:9 timeline	Accessible browser editor; hard cuts preserved the intended 25-second runtime.
Music	Premium/SFX assets vs free Music assets	Microsoft Clipchamp Music library	Non-premium instrumental music avoided paid assets and kept the score beneath the image track.

Model-switching protocol

OPERATIONAL RULE A model change is safe only when the hand-off packet is stronger than the model-specific chat history. Treat the packet as the source of truth; treat each model as an interchangeable production workstation.

- Store the current story logline, audience decision, and scene order in plain text.
- Record the exact model, product surface, prompt version, and output filename for every approved asset.
- Add a “do not change” block: character descriptions, vehicle design, costume, palette, aspect ratio, duration, and end-title wording.
- Record the active task, blocked task, daily-limit status, and next action before changing tools.
- After transfer, ask the next model to restate the brief before it generates or edits anything.

Technical controls that protected the final cut

- Aspect ratio lock: generate and edit in 16:9 from the first still onward.
- Shot-length lock: five scenes x five seconds; transition overlaps were rejected because a 0.5-second cross fade subtracts time from the total timeline.
- Prompt-control pattern: action + atmosphere + camera + preserve constraints + negative constraints.
- Asset hygiene: upload one file at a time when batch imports stall; use scene-numbered files instead of relying on thumbnail recognition.
- Typography control: generated text was treated as unreliable; the final title was built natively in Microsoft Clipchamp.
- Audio control: use Music rather than SFX, avoid premium-marked assets, keep score at roughly 15-20%, and fade within the final second.

Hand-off brief schema

COPYABLE TEMPLATE PROJECT: Sui Dhaaga - The Road Trip Tailors | CURRENT STAGE: [stage] | MODEL/TOOL: [name + version] | STORY: [one sentence] | LOCKED ANCHORS: [characters, van, palette, costume] | APPROVED ASSETS: [file names] | PROMPTS USED: [version / location] | EDIT TARGET: 16:9, 25 sec | KNOWN ISSUE: [limit/error] | NEXT ACTION: [single concrete action]

8. Replication workflow: concept to production

Use this flow as the studio's repeatable operating model. The outputs of one stage become the constraints of the next; do not skip the lock points.

CHAT IDEATE	**POLL CHOOSE**	**BIBLE LOCK**	**GEMINI STILLS**	**PIKA MOTION**	**CLIPCHAMP EDIT**	**EXPORT REVIEW**

Flagship-project checklist

Gate	Question
Idea	Can the premise be understood without dialogue?
Audience	Was the chosen idea selected against genuine alternatives?
Continuity	Are character, vehicle, costume, palette, and prop anchors documented?
Still images	Does each approved still have a clear action and stable composition?
Motion	Does every Pika prompt specify a few actions, camera behaviour, and "preserve" constraints?
Edit	Does the timeline hold the intended runtime after transitions?
Sound	Is the music licensed/usable, quiet, and faded at the end?
Reflection	Can the student name one failure and the correction that improved the final film?

Instructor debrief: what this project teaches

- AI filmmaking is an art of constraints: fewer shots, stronger anchors, and deliberate selection beat endless generation.
- Images are not the film; shot purpose, motion design, sound, and timing create the film.
- Generated text and transitions must be treated critically. Put important titles in the editor; verify runtime after any overlap effect.
- A small project can be a flagship project when every decision is documented clearly enough for another maker to repeat and improve it.

FINAL ASSIGNMENT Create your own five-scene, 25-second AI short. Keep one recurring visual anchor, solicit an audience choice among four concepts, document every prompt, and submit the final video with a one-page production reflection.

9. Publication: a permanent home for the film

A finished film that lives only as an attachment dies in the feed. This project publishes to platforms that persist, accumulate, and can be extended with every new case study: YouTube hosts the film, GitHub hosts the complete production archive, and social posts only carry links.

The film on YouTube

- Channel: AI Movie Lab (@AIMovieLab_Pathikrit), a dedicated brand channel so future films build one audience.
- Video: https://youtu.be/rXJDMQSXumg - the 1080p export, uploaded unlisted first for review, then made public.
- Disclosure: YouTube requires the "altered or synthetic content" declaration for realistic AI imagery; it was enabled at upload, together with the not-made-for-kids setting.

The archive on GitHub

- Repository: github.com/pathikritroy-india/ai-movie-lab - this guide, the locked master poster, the five approved scene stills, and both model hand-off briefs, all version-controlled.
- Public site: https://pathikritroy-india.github.io/ai-movie-lab/ - a permanent GitHub Pages URL that renders the case study for any visitor; new case studies become new folders and sections, so the archive compounds.
- Versioning: guide editions are kept side by side (V1.2, V1.3, V1.4, ...) instead of overwritten - the same discipline the production itself used for stills and briefs.

PUBLICATION RULE Post links, not files. Feeds bury attachments within days; a YouTube video and a GitHub Pages site keep working, keep compounding, and give every future project a ready audience. Disclose AI-generated content honestly wherever the platform provides for it.

The finished film in five frames





Departure > Threads of Kutch > Temple Thread > Bengal Finale > The Road Continues.

THE JOURNEY CONTINUES..

A 25-second AI film, produced from idea to final cut.

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